

BENEATH THEIR FEET TMC minority cell activists at an anti-SIR protest, Kolkata, Jan. 19

DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

over 187,000 names have been deleted.

About 132,000 deletions were in seats the BJP won in 2021, compared with roughly 54,600 in seats held by Trinamool Congress (TMC), meaning nearly 70 per cent of all deletions in these constituencies are concentrated in BJP strongholds. Put another way, of the 20 reserved seats that have seen the highest deletions, 14 were won by the BJP last time.

The pattern persists even outside of reserved seats. If one looks at the total of 63.6 million votes deleted in the SIR, of the 10 constituencies with the highest deletions, the BJP had won nine seats in 2021—Dabgram-Fulbari (16,491 deletions), Bagda (15,303), Santipur (8,048), Bongaon Uttar (7,926), Ranaghat Dakshin (7,126), Ranaghat Uttar Purba (6,404), Ranaghat Uttar Paschim (6,704), Chakdaha (5,864) and Siliguri (5,240). The only exception was Habra, held by the TMC.

Takeaways

- **Of the 10 seats with the most deletions, the BJP had won nine in 2021**
- **187,000 reserved seat deletions mostly hit BJP; Muslims in technical limbo**

DOUBLY DISENFRANCHISED

These constituencies, in fact, formed the backbone of the BJP's 2021 breakthrough in southern Bengal—especially in a belt straddling Nadia-North 24 Parganas. Some of these seats have since changed hands through defections and bypolls, but the region continues to be considered a core area of BJP strength. The concentration of deletions in these seats raises an obvious question: will the SIR end up reshaping the electorate in ways counterproductive to the BJP?

Closely linked to this is the second concern, centred on the Matua belt. Many seats with the highest deletions are dominated by the Matua community, a large Dalit grouping of refugee origin. The BJP's electoral expansion in Bengal over the past decade relied heavily on mobilising this community that immigrated from Bangladesh over the years. Central to its outreach were promises related to citizenship and recognition. That is under serious stress.

Suvendu Adhikari, BJP heavyweight and leader of the Opposition, seems cognisant of the danger. He has tried to reassure the community, saying all Matuas who have applied or will apply for citizenship will get it and be thus enfranchised again. But the community does not quite seem ready to believe that. Trust lies very shaken by the SIR.

The constituencies of Bagda, Bongaon Uttar, Santipur and the Ranaghat cluster form part of the broader Matua belt in Nadia and North 24 Parganas. These areas were central to the BJP's strong performance even in the 2019 and 2024 parliamentary elections.

MINORITY REPORT

If the first two patterns create discomfort for the BJP, the third and perhaps most politically sensitive trend concerns the TMC. According to SIR data, 6 million voters across Bengal have been placed under adjudication, meaning their eligibility or documentation is still being examined by judicial officers by order of the SC. To put things into context, only about 188,000 new voters have been added.

The geographical distribution of these cases is particularly noteworthy. Of the 10 districts with the most voters under adjudication, nine have Muslim populations ranging from 40 per cent to 90 per cent—Murshidabad, Malda, North 24 Parganas, South 24 Parganas, Uttar Dinajpur, Purba Bardhaman, Howrah, Nadia and Birbhum. Murshidabad alone has over 1.1 million such cases, Malda accounts for over 800,000, and North 24 Parganas nearly 600,000.

These districts form the heart of Bengal's minority electorate. Murshidabad contains 22 assembly seats where Muslim voters account for between 40 and 90 per cent of the population. In 2021, the TMC won 20 of these seats; the BJP managed to win Berhampore and Murshidabad, but only due to a split in Muslim votes between the TMC and the Congress.

Malda presents a slightly different landscape. The district has eight constituencies with Muslim populations between 40 and 90 per cent, all won by the TMC in 2021. Yet the Congress retains deep roots in parts of Malda and Murshidabad, so minority votes are not always consolidated. For the TMC, therefore, the unusually large number of voters under adjudication in these districts is a real threat. If even a fraction of these votes remain unresolved or excluded, the math could change. ■